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[00:15:09] The House will come to order. Members, please take your seats. Head page. The House is now in session. All persons not entitled to privileges of the floor, please retire to the gallery.

[00:15:25] The members will rise and be led in prayer by Reverend Mike Maton, Senior Pastor by our United Methodist Church, North Chesterfield, and remain standing for the Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America, which will be led by the Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Shall we pray? Almighty God, whom we know by many names, fill each of these individuals working here today, And this collective body, this house of delegates, with your righteousness to guide their lives and direct their paths.

[00:15:54] Your sacred scriptures tell us that righteousness is not just one that turns their face to the east or the west, simply outward signs, but is genuine belief, the practice of faith in you. Fill us, O Holy One, draw us closer to you, to one another, and to all of creation by thy righteousness, so that these elected officials, your servants, will faithfully guide their neighbors in all that is right, just, and beneficial, and as the need requires.

[00:16:23] And encourage us by the presence of your justice, grace, and the standard of true life to be instruments of righteousness to protect, guide, and lift up the people of the Commonwealth of Virginia, to

give hope to all who do rightly, and to be a light to the nations, and God bless Ms. Peggy in the members' lounge now and always. Amen. Amen. Amen.

[00:16:47] To the flag of the United States of America, and to the republic for which it stands, one nation, under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all. The members will answer the roll call

[00:17:18] by indicating their presence on the electronic voting board. Clerk will close the roll. Mr. Mr. Speaker, a quorum is present.

[00:17:35] Pursuant to House Rule 3, I have examined and approved the adjourned House of Delegates for February 25th, 2026. Most of the resolutions under Rule 39 pursuant to the provisions of Rule 40 are now in order. Does the clerk have any announcements or communication? Communication, Mr. Speaker, communication from the Senate. The Senate has rejected the substitute proposed by the House of Delegates to Senate Bill 203.

[00:17:56] Delegate from Roanoke City, Delegate Rasul. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House recede from its substitute to Senate Bill 203, and I'd like to speak to that motion. Douglas, the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. With that rescission, then we would actually be in line with the House bill that we passed yesterday, 332, with regards to teacher licensure.

[00:18:15] I hope it be the pleasure of the body, as we have this recorded vote, to recede from its substitute to Senate Bill 203. Shall the House recede from its substitute to Senate Bill 203? It's a recorded vote. Mr. Speaker.

[00:18:46] Delegate from Scott County, Delegate Kilgore. Mr. Speaker, would the gentleman, can I ask a question at this stage? Delegate yield? I yield. Delegate yield. Could the gentleman tell me what the vote was when it passed the House? Yes, thank you. So the House Bill 332 passed unanimously, so nothing is happening here.

[00:19:03] We're actually taking the Senate language, Mr. Speaker. So they'll be happy with that, but that puts both bills in line.

[00:19:10] Clerk will close the roll.

[00:21:10] Ayes 97, no zero. Ayes 97, no zero. The motion is agreed to. Ms. Speaker, in this first portion of the morning hour, pursuant to House Rule 40, the Speaker asks you to use your Request to Speak button for the agenda items listed up at reference on the voting board. Delegate from Falkirk County, Delegate Weber.

[00:21:27] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for an introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, the gentleman who gave the prayer today, Reverend Mike Matin, is a lifelong Virginian who currently serves as pastor of Bon Air United Methodist Church.

[00:21:44] He has served numerous Methodist churches across the Commonwealth, Newport News, Winchester, Stephen City. He holds degrees from Wesley Theological Seminary, Christopher Newport College, and went to York High School in Yorktown, Mr. Speaker.

[00:22:02] His wife, Cheryl, is retired from the Virginia Department of Education, and his daughter is currently pursuing her master's in psychology at Liberty University. Mr. Speaker, I am also grateful that he knows how important Ms. Peggy and our staff are to us, and I ask that the House give him a warm House welcome.

[00:22:26] Welcome, welcome, Reverend Maiton. Welcome to the Capitol. The Delegate from Chesapeake, Delegate Lefwich. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a motion. The Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:22:42] Mr. Speaker, I ask that we take up House Joint Resolution 177 on page 40 of the calendar out order. Clerk, report a resolution. House Joint Resolution number 177, celebrating the life of the Honorable Barry D. Knight.

[00:23:00] Delegate from Chesapeake, Delegate Lefwich. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Speaking briefly to the motion. The Delegate has the floor. While my heart would like to say a lot more about Delegate Knight, there's been much already said. And so at this juncture, what I'd simply say is that we want to try to get this resolution signed by everyone so that we can present it to the family this weekend.

[00:23:19] You have until 5 o'clock this afternoon to do that. An electronic invitation is going out to everybody in both chambers, and my staff has been going around every office. So please make an effort to sign that and mean a great deal to the family.

[00:23:36] And so with that, Mr. Speaker, I ask that the resolution pass. The Delegate from Chesapeake, Delegate Leftwich, moves the adoption of House Joint Resolution 177 and that when the House adjourns today, it adjourned today in the honor and memory of Barry D. Knight.

[00:23:52] All those in favor shall rise. The motion is agreed to.

[00:24:09] Delegate from Chesterfield, Delegate Gartner. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for a motion. The Delegate has the floor. I move that H.R. 129, found on page 8 of the calendar, be taken up out of order.

[00:24:32] FERC will put a resolution. House Resolution 129, celebrating the life of Evelyn Willanette Morris Harris. And I would ask that her family please stand. For more than 30 years of dedicated public service, Evelyn Willanette Morris Harris played a vital role in advancing democratic leadership and civic engagement throughout the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[00:24:58] Her work reflected a deep commitment to public service, voter engagement, and strengthening the democratic institutions at the local and state level. Throughout her career, Evelyn Moore Harris supported and collaborated with numerous elected public officials.

[00:25:17] She was actively involved in coordinating campaign operations, constituent outreach, and grassroots mobilization efforts that contributed to successful electoral outcomes across multiple election cycles.

[00:25:34] Her work often bridged campaign strategy with community engagement, ensuring that policy priorities remain connected to the voices of Virginian residents. Her legacy is one of quiet leadership, tireless dedication, and unwavering belief in the democratic process.

[00:25:55] Evelyn Moore Harris's contributions have helped shape policy outcomes, strengthen political infrastructure, and support leaders who continue to serve the Commonwealth today, even a couple of us in this body. Her impact will be felt long after her passing through the people she supported, the campaign she strengthened, and the values she upheld.

[00:26:17] That's why I move this resolution and ask that when we adjourn today, we adjourn in the memory of Evelyn Willanette Morris Harris. Delegate from Chesterfield, Delegate Gardner moves the

adoption of House Resolution 129 and that when the House adjourns today, it adjourn in the honoring memory of Evelyn Willanette Morris Harris.

[00:26:39] All those in favor of the motion shall rise. The motion is agreed to. Delegate from Lynchburg, Delegate Walker.

[00:27:05] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an introduction. Doug, it has the floor. Joining us in the gallery today is Brookville High School Political Science Club, and I ask if they stand to be recognized. Led by their teacher, Mr. Aaron Scott, and their school board member, Ann Parker, these bright young people are from Campbell County, and they represent the future of Virginia.

[00:27:29] They're here today to learn more about the work that we do at the Capitol and to hear from legislators. I've been fortunate to visit their club and hear from these students about issues that concern them. Their thoughtful questions and interest in work that we do are a reminder of the next generation that are paying attention.

[00:27:50] Mr. Speaker, they're preparing to leave the Commonwealth. If you see them around the Capitol today, make sure you say hello to the Brookville Bees from Lynchburg, Virginia. I ask that you give them a nice house welcome today. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:28:16] Delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Delaney. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Today it is my pleasure to recognize the Virginia Asphalt Association as they celebrate an extraordinary milestone, 75 years of service to the Commonwealth.

[00:28:32] The association has represented an industry that quite literally paves the way for progress across our state. On behalf of this body, I ask that we congratulate the Virginia Asphalt Association on their 75th anniversary and thank them for their continued partnership in building a stronger, safer, and more sustainable Commonwealth and hope we offer them a warm house welcome.

[00:28:53] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Delegate for Hanover, Delegate Fowler. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purpose of an introduction.

[00:29:14] Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, members of the House, today in the gallery, we have a group of students from Patrick Henry High School in western Hanover County. The PH Patriots are here with their government teacher, Mr. Keith Braxton.

[00:29:33] Mr. Speaker, I'll ask that our guests from Patrick Henry High School please stand. Mr. Speaker, Patrick Henry High School, in many ways, is the heart and soul of western Hanover County.

[00:29:56] In the 1960s and 70s, there were only two schools in Hanover County, Mr. Speaker. Patrick Henry and their cross-country rivals, Lee Davis High School. The rivalries were intense, but the competition was important to both schools.

[00:30:13] Mr. Speaker, Patrick Henry High School enjoys strong academic, music, and athletic programs. as well as an exceptional NJROTC program. Mr. Speaker, I would ask the members to please join me and give our guests from Patrick Henry High School a warm house welcome.

[00:30:39] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate McGuire. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:30:55] Today in the gallery, we have the leadership from United Community, a nationally recognized nonprofit along the Route 1 corridor of Fairfax County, which serves residents in both the 17th District and 16th District. This organization is dedicated to building a thriving community where every family has the power, tools, and resources to confidently shape their future and raise the next generation with dignity and opportunity.

[00:31:15] Founded in 1969, United Community has served residents for over 57 years with programs such as medical and nutrition services, early childhood education, counseling, workforce readiness, and more. United Community's goal is not just to meet immediate needs, but work alongside the community to address systemic barriers, uplift, voices, and chart a path forward.

[00:31:35] Mr. Speaker, on behalf of myself, who's the current board chair of United Community, Delegate Kreczek, whose mother won a Lifetime Achievement Award from United Community, and Delegate McClure, whose mother worked for United Community, I would hope it's the will of the House to give them a warm house welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:32:03] Delegate from Shutter Door, Delegate Pence. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an announcement. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I would like to remind the body that tonight is the reception honoring Virginia Farm Bureau's 100th anniversary. A bus will be provided and parked between the GAB and Old City Hall and is scheduled to leave approximately at 5 o'clock.

[00:32:23] And we'll have you back here by 7. At 5.45, our speaker and newest Farm Bureau member will give remarks along with the Farm Bureau president. Please join us for the event celebrating Virginia agriculture. Thank you. The delegate from Suffolk, Delegate Clark.

[00:32:42] Mr. Speaker, I rise for a motion. The delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House take up out of order H.R. 158, found on page 9 of today's calendar. Clerk, report a resolution. House Resolution 158, commending the Epsilon Iota Lambda Chapter of Alpha Phi Alpha Fraternity Incorporated.

[00:33:01] Delegate from Suffolk, Delegate Clark. Mr. Speaker, I move the adoption of the resolution and request to speak to the motion. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker and members of the House. I rise today to recognize and commend an organization whose legacy of service has strengthened families, empowered young people, and uplifted communities across Southeast Virginia for three-quarters of a century.

[00:33:21] The Epsilon Iota Lambda Chapter of Alpha Phi Alpha Fraternity Incorporated. Oh, y'all are already standing. I was about to tell y'all to stand. Founded on October 1, 1950 and inspired by the enduring principles of Alpha Phi Alpha Fraternity Incorporated scholarship, service, and brotherhood.

[00:33:36] This distinguished chapter was established by visionary men who recognized the need for organizing mentorship, civic leadership, and community engagement in Suffolk and Smithfield. With the support of the Zeta Lambda Chapter of Alpha Phi Alpha Fraternity, Incorporated, and under the leadership of the first president, W. Lavelle Turner, the chapter began its legacy that continues to thrive today.

[00:34:00] For 75 years, the Epsilon Iota Lambda Chapter has been a steadfast pillar in Franklin, Isle of Wight, Southampton County, Sussex County, Smithfield, and neighboring communities. Throughout signature events such as the Charter Breakfast, Black and Gold Gala, their annual golf tournament, and

through impactful national initiatives including Brothers Keepers, a vote list people as a hopeless people, go to high school and go to college, and Project Alpha.

[00:34:27] The chapter has demonstrated what sustained commitment to service truly looks like. Their impact is measurable and meaningful. Each year, they provide food assistance to more than 10,000 families in the community. They have awarded over $75,000 in scholarships to deserving students.

[00:34:45] They have supported environmental, educational, humanitarian, and civic causes that strengthen the very fabric of our commonwealth. For generations, the Epsilon Iota Lambda Chapter has stood as a beacon of leadership and collective responsibility. Today, as we celebrate their 75th anniversary, we honor not only their history, but their continued dedication to building stronger communities and brighter future.

[00:35:09] Mr. Speaker, it is with great pride that we commend the Epsilon Iota Lambda Chapter of Alpha Phi Alpha Fraternity Incorporated and extend it to our members our sincere admiration and gratitude for their enduring contributions to Southeast Virginia and the Commonwealth as a whole.

[00:35:26] Thank you, Mr. Speaker, and I move the adoption of the resolution. Delegate from Suffolk, Delegate Clark, move that we adopt House Resolution 158, commending the Epsilon Iota Lambda Chapter of Alpha Phi Alpha Fraternity Incorporated. All those in favor say aye. All those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. Congratulations.

[00:35:56] Delegate from Chesapeake, Delegate Lethbridge. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Today in the gallery, we have representatives of Farmers Bank. And Farmers Bank, if y'all could please rise. Farmers Bank specializes in home ownership loans and small business loans in rural areas.

[00:36:16] And today we have with us from Farmers Bank Eli Sawyer, and he's accompanied by former House Member Thoma Drake and former Congressman Thoma Drake. So I'd ask that the body give these individuals and Farmers Bank a warm house welcome.

[00:36:34] Thank you. Welcome to the Capitol, and good to see you, Congresswoman or Delegate or whatever, all the titles you've had. Welcome back. The Delegate from Richmond, Delegate Carr.

[00:36:51] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a motion. The Delegate has the floor. Thank you. I move that we take H.R. 176 on page 42, and then we take it up out of order, and I move its adoption. Clerk will report a resolution.

[00:37:07] House Resolution No. 176, commending Tom Kirkland, optician. The delegate from Richmond City, Delegate Carr, move that we adopt House Resolution 176. All those in favor, say aye. All those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. Pursuant to House Rule 30, the general shall reflect that the following members are away on pressing personal business and are granted leave from today's session, Delegate Williams.

[00:37:29] Clerk will announce the next order of business. Mr. Speaker, the second portion of the morning hour is reserved for the announcement of member requests to move legislation from any uncontested block over to the regular. There are three on that first category on today's calendar, Senate Bill's third reading, uncontested calendar, pages 1 and 2, Senator SB 303 by Senator Jordan, Senator French's SB 385, and Senator Cipher's SB 462.

[00:37:58] all of those are out of the uncontested calendar blog over to the regular calendar at the request of Delegate Tran. Clerk will announce the next one. Third portion of the morning hour is reserved for member requests for legislation to go by for the day. Mr. Speaker, I'm not aware of any such requests today. Clerk will announce the next one. Mr. Speaker, on this budget day, the fourth and final portion of the morning hour is reserved for member requests for points of personal privilege.

[00:38:18] Speaker, Kyle, I ask you to use your request speak button to get into the queue.

[00:38:32] Delegate from Powhatan, Delegate Ware. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a point of personal privilege. Doug, that's the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise to speak to a bill that will shortly come before us. And ladies and gentlemen of the House, please allow me to meditate with you as a student of history and for over 30 years, a teacher of history to high school students of every complexion. I offer the following observations as a contribution to Black History Month. And I note that my great-great-grandfather was a colonel, the colonel on the 44th

[00:39:06] Massachusetts. He led troops in the War of 1861 in both North and South Carolina. After his servant service in the field, he became a military advisor to the legislature of his home state. That Union officer's comrade and friend was Charles Francis Adams Jr., who was the grandson and great-grandson of U.S. Presidents John Quincy Adams and John Adams, respectively. Charles Jr. served with distinction at Gettysburg and then was named colonel of the fabled 5th Massachusetts Colored Volunteer Cavalry.

[00:39:43] To add to the drama, Colonel Adams' father was Mr. Lincoln's U.S. minister to Great Britain, and he was instrumental in preventing the United Kingdom from siding with the Confederacy. You see then, these men were opposed to Virginia in 1861.

[00:40:01] And yet, it was Charles Francis Adams Jr. who in 1907 was asked to give the centennial address on the birth of none other than Robert E. Lee at Washington and Lee University here in Lexington.

[00:40:17] Let us take to heart this great man's pedigree as we remember that he spoke with admiration of the Confederate commander whose army Adams himself had opposed with arms. Indeed, Adams declared that General Lee, in the manner of his surrender at Appomattox, did nothing less than, and I quote, save the country, end quote.

[00:40:41] North and South saved us, Adams meant, from further years of bloodshed and division. At a later speech, Adams confessed that had he been in Lee's position in 1861, he would have done as Lee had done, side with his state, in opposition to the federal government.

[00:41:01] For in its essence, Adams believed the war was about sovereignty, where it rested, either in Washington or in the capitals of the individual states. That is why many... refer to that tragic conflict as the war between the states.

[00:41:18] But it was also a civil war. It was a civil war because it was a war between cousins. In this, the teacher in me calls our attention to the English Civil War of the 1640s when Oliver Cromwell led an army that defeated Crown and Parliament and executed the very King of England.

[00:41:39] Not only before, but especially after that terrible conflict, the English who migrated to this country came either to New England, the land of the original Puritans, or to Virginia, home of the royal supporters known as, think of UVA, the Cavaliers.

[00:41:57] Kevin Phillips, in a work entitled The Cousins' War, traces America's rise to international greatness, to the combined effects of the English Civil War, the American Revolution, again, English fighting English, and our Civil War, emphasizing that these wars and their outcomes combined to forge the crucible in which, for example, black history became possible and has risen to new heights today in this very chamber.

[00:42:28] Soon we will take up Senate Bill 636, proposing to remove the McGuire, Smith, and Jackson monuments from Capitol Square. But have you ever stopped to read the inscription on the Jackson statue? I ask because the Jackson statue was not paid for by Virginians or Southerners.

[00:42:53] The inscription reads, presented by English gentlemen as a tribute of admiration for the soldier and patriot Thomas J. Jackson, done in 1875, just over 150 years ago. The story of Jackson becomes even more compelling because the stained glass window behind the pulpit of Fifth Avenue Presbyterian Church in Roanoke is a memorial to Jackson and quotes his dying words.

[00:43:19] Let us cross over the river and rest under the shade of the trees. That church is a black church whose early pastor was the son of parents who were taught the Christian faith and taught to read by then VMI professor Thomas Jonathan Jackson.

[00:43:39] As a lady of the church remarked to the press a couple of years ago, Jackson was a man of Christ. And as the pastor of that church conceded, the story of Jackson is complicated. His word, the complications, the ironies, the imperfections of every individual and of all history.

[00:44:00] was the central tenet, the complicated truth that I emphasize to students in all my classes and which I would emphasize to all of us today. For example, we've recently heard much about year 1619, as we should.

[00:44:17] But what I ask my students of 1519, 1419, 1319, for the answer, let's go even further back, a thousand years. Historians estimate that starting around the year 650, some seven centuries before Europeans explored Africa, and 10 centuries before West Africans were sold across the Atlantic to America, more than 18 million people from East Africa were enslaved by Arabs and taken across the Sahara Desert, the Red Sea, and the Indian Ocean.

[00:44:57] From 1525 onward, quote, 90% of Africans shipped to the New World were enslaved by Africans and then sold to Europeans. That last statistic is from a short commentary by Harvard professor Henry Louis Gates, Jr., and who, as older among us will know, is a distinguished scholar who is black.

[00:45:21] The title of his principled commentary in this area is Ending the Slavery Blame Game. Elsewhere, Professor Gates writes, and I quote, Perhaps you, like me, were raised to think of the slave experience primarily in terms of our black ancestors in the United States.

[00:45:43] Well, think again, wrote the professor. Starting in 1525, 12 and a half Africans were shipped to the New World. 10.7 million survived the passage. And here I'm quoting Professor Gates again.

[00:46:01] And how many of these 10.7 million Africans were shipped to North America? About 388,800, a tiny percentage. Excuse me, Professor Gates concludes, the sad truth is that the conquest and capture of Africans and their sale to Europeans was one of the main sources of foreign exchange for several African kingdoms for a very long time.

[00:46:29] In other words, he concludes, and again, I quote, We must attribute responsibility and culpability where they truly belong, to white people and black people, on both sides of the Atlantic. The patron of the bill soon to be before us has said that he does not want children visiting Capitol Square to see, quote, inappropriate monuments to grotesque people.

[00:46:55] But do we remember, hearkening back, Oliver Cromwell, the Englishman who defeated Parliament and killed a king? Outside Britain's very Houses of Parliament in London is a towering monument to that one-time enemy of the crown, Oliver Cromwell.

[00:47:14] So let us indeed add to Capitol Square a monument to another great Virginian, Booker T. Washington. But let us keep Jackson and Billy Smith and Dr. McGuire as the contemporaries of Booker T. Washington himself, who provide the very context of the raw and imperfect history of that time in which he lived and went on to his great work.

[00:47:43] In a similar vein, the patron of a principal bill concerning VMI has denounced men such as Jackson as traitors. But my friends, in 1860, most Americans considered their state, not the Federal Union, to be their country.

[00:47:59] This was because the average soldier in the war on both sides had traveled not more than 20 miles from home. Historians call the war the summit of a tragic era because it forced men such as Jackson to choose between loyalties, to be a traitor to neither one, but to remain loyal to only one.

[00:48:24] Studying this era is vitally important for our children of all races, precisely because it was a complicated and tragic and therefore a great era in our shared history.

[00:48:41] There are vitally important historical, political, social, and even spiritual lessons in this. It is my suggestion that the only way we can give our children an understanding of history is by eschewing the simplistic slogans of our time and instead teaching our children how to delve into the context of the times that they are studying.

[00:49:07] Men and women of the past can be understood only in the context of their times, because history is, to say the least, as that black pastor in Roanoke remarked, complicated. Many years ago in this building, I spoke on the complexity of history in this fashion.

[00:49:26] Lee Jackson and Martin Luther King Jr., Christians all, would have appreciated as providential the proximity of the dates of their birth. And it may well be that even today or in some great day to come, in the realm where the spirits of the just are made perfect, R.E. Lee, Stonewall Jackson, and Martin Luther King Jr. are side by side at the Supper of the Lamb.

[00:49:56] This, my friends, is the understanding that we bequeath to our children and our children's children, that there has been greatness and goodness in men and women of every race, even when in opposite circumstances in the long centuries of the past, and that every human being, every human endeavor, is infected with imperfection, even evil.

[00:50:20] To their question, who is responsible for that evil? I repeat the answer I gave my students. Everyone is responsible. There is no innocence in human history, but grace is everywhere.

[00:50:39] And if a simpler lesson would suffice, allow me to cite the refrain of the heart of the matter. And it's to the heart of the matter of our history that I appeal. In the well-known lyrics of Don Henley, I've been trying to get down to the heart of the matter.

[00:50:56] But my will gets weak, and my thoughts seem to scatter. But I think it's about forgiveness, forgiveness, even if, even if you don't love me anymore.

[00:51:14] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Prince William, Delegate Maldonado. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:51:30] Mr. Speaker, I rise for your point of personal privilege. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I am astounded at what we just heard from the delegate. soft words, equating what was pure inhumanity, murder, rape, pillage, in our history, and using

[00:52:04] language about both sides. There's no both sides. And when we say that Africans participated in the slave trade, let's be clear. Slavery as embraced in this country did not replicate the slavery that we saw around the world the united states the predecessor of the united states used chattel slavery it was so offensive so inhumane that even the nazis came to us to explain how do you do that

[00:52:40] how can we embrace that and adopt it in what we are doing against jews in germany and you know what they decided mr speaker they said that's even too much for us there is no both sides there was no fairness and there is also no equivocating statues in public places for people who looked at people like me and people who look like me as less than human. Mr. Speaker, when I travel the

[00:53:14] world and I go to places like Germany, they ask me, why in your country do you erect statutes to people who went against your government, people who killed people, people who saw you as less than human. We're not allowed to do that here. It's illegal. Because around the world, countries have recognized what genocide looks like. They have looked like, they have understood what it looks like to take away a people's culture, a people's language, a people's history, a people's

[00:53:48] tradition in the name of oppression and power. And so when we talk about removing statutes, we aren't talking about disrespecting history. We are talking about restoring the accurate narrative of history. And let me just say, Mr. Speaker, that it is offensive as an African American woman in this chamber to hear people say the history is complicated. Yeah, it's complicated. But let's

[00:54:24] be clear that the complication isn't because people who look like me helped people who didn't look like me, enslave my people, be brutal with my people, rape my people, oppress my people, and then go into Jim Crow, then go into other things that for centuries have made it harder for black and brown people to thrive, to have the same access, to be able to have their children enjoy generational wealth.

[00:54:57] These things that we keep saying are in the past, while they may have occurred in the past. The systems have tentacles that reach into the present day and are spreading into the future unless we stand together and say no more. No more. And we have examples of how to do that.

[00:55:18] We have courageous people who have spoken up to do that. And Mr. Speaker, today is no different.

[00:55:24] Thank you. Delegate from Buckingham, Delegate Garrett. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise to join my colleague from Prince William in saying no more. Is this a point of personal privilege?

[00:56:03] sir. I do, Mr. Speaker. Okay. No more. No more. I was so inspired yesterday, Mr. Speaker, when we had three points of personal privilege in a row. Mine was like B minus material. And then the delegate from Bucking or Suffolk stood up and gave, you know, a pretty good point where he asked an incredibly poignant question. When I hear MAGA, I think, okay, when, if we're going to make America great again,

what do we want to go back to? And I thought that's a reasonable, fair question. And then my friend, I mean, I had tears in my eyes when I went over there to speak

[00:56:39] to the delegate from Norfolk, because I normally pray before a speech, dear God, help me do the best I can with the gifts that you've given me. And yesterday I was praying, dear God, take this thing and do with it what you want. I don't know why I was praying a different prayer, but I was. And so I haven't had the same life experience, Mr. Speaker, as the delegate from Prince William. And I acknowledge that. And I like her and I respect her. And I wasn't offended by the comments of the delegate of Powhatan, right?

[00:57:10] But what we started to have yesterday, Mr. Speaker, wasn't points of personal privilege, it was a discussion. It was a discussion about America, it was a discussion about race, and it needs to be had. I wish that everybody could have grown up with my dad, who went to a segregated school in Richmond, Virginia, in the 1950s and 60s, and who told me almost with tears in his eyes of stuff that he saw as a little white boy that was indefensible.

[00:57:36] And that man also told me of the virtues of some of the people who Delegate Ware spoke of. And that man had people in our home who didn't look like him, and they had conversations at a dinner table that I needed to hear so that we could say together, sincerely, I'm not trying to, like, pick fights. No more.

[00:57:55] I said yesterday, Mr. Speaker, that the point of testimony isn't the testimony. It's what we learn from the testimony. So I think that this conversation is super, super important. I think it needs to be had, and I think that we need to own our—we own our country's history.

[00:58:12] but i'm going to focus on the plural here on purpose first speech was i said if disenfranchisement was wrong then it's wrong now then the delegate from suffolk said as a black man and i hear maga i wonder what when you want to make america back to fair question and then i hear delegate from norfolk say shame on people who perverted my bible written to free all people to use it to enslave some wow she said further that it's good that we had a constitution that allowed us to move towards a more perfect union despite our evil which i'll own except i didn't do it and then She said, if we want to move forward, we have to acknowledge lynching and Jim Crow and slavery.

[00:58:52] Okay, we do. I am not lessening that because there's nothing small about that horror. But if you Google where was chattel slavery used throughout history, it'll tell you all over the world. In fact, the word slave is derived from the word Slav.

[00:59:10] It's bad everywhere. And we did it here and we have to own it. I love America. I hope you love America. I was born with American privilege. The odds of being born in this country are 1 in 26.

[00:59:26] I've been so incredibly blessed to spend the night in, what, four of the seven state sponsors of terrorism. I brought with me this morning, Mr. Speaker, a book given to me by a dear friend, Mustafa Ismail, who is a Kurd from northern Iraq. That's him on the cover with his wife and their child. I love the Kurds.

[00:59:44] I'm going to get back to that in just a second. Because the human story transcends evil that existed, yes, and still exists to some degree, horrifically, here in this country. All these horrible things are real, but again, the purpose of testimony isn't the testimony, it's what do we learn.

[01:00:05] And so in my speech I wrote, don't do it, never again, never again. So I'm with you, my colleague from Prince William. I love America despite its failures, not because of them. Despite its evils, not because of them. But let me digress for a moment.

[01:00:23] How do you destroy something? How do you fill a vacuum? You must first create a vacuum. And so there is a playbook in Marxism that says we pit one group of people against another group of people. And in the former Soviet Union, it worked really well, because there was a permanent enslaved class, but they weren't slaves, in the form of the proletariat and a permanent perpetual ruling class in form of royalty.

[01:00:48] And they said, "These people got. You don't got. Go take it. You have as much right to it as they do," which was actually kind of true in its face. It didn't work in America. And so, when Jim Crow was very real in oppressing millions upon millions of Americans who didn't do anything wrong, who didn't deserve it, they said, "Ah, here's an idea.

[01:01:08] If we can't pit one American against another based on material wealth because there's just too much fluidity up and down, maybe we'll find an immutable character trait that we can use to pit one man against his brother. This is my daddy at the dining room table with his friend right now.

[01:01:24] What is it that God gave us as a gift that the devil can leverage to draw a wedge between people who should love each other? I am not denying the horrific evil, nor am I attempting to downplay it.

[01:01:39] And if I do, I sincerely apologize. But they want to destroy America so that they can consolidate power. Indeed, Marxism has never failed, because it's failed everywhere it's been tried. It's never failed to consolidate ultimate and supreme power into the hands of a very few at the expense of the masses.

[01:01:57] Stalin never lost his Black Sea dasha when people were starving to death in the potato—when there were no potatoes. Instead, he sat on the beach and ordered his neighbor's dog murdered because he could. And that, too, is injustice. So, we have these people telling us that America is bad, bad, bad, bad.

[01:02:15] America has been bad. And America has been great. America has been great. When was America great? It was great in 1776, when a slave-owning person named Jefferson drafted a Declaration of Independence that originally contained provisions that would have eliminated slavery, but two states held out, and they needed unanimity, and so they were cast by the wayside.

[01:02:37] If you read Jefferson's writings, you understand that he knew that, while he was doing it, what he was doing was horrible and evil. And he should have known it. So it was great, but it was broken. I like to talk about the word "more" and "more perfect union."

[01:02:52] It was great in 1791, when James Madison gave us the Constitution that created an apparatus by which we could make changes, right, imperfect people, near-perfect ideas. It was great in 1862 at Antietam, when 23,000 Americans murdered one another, killed, wounded, and missing, in one day, the bloodiest day in American history.

[01:03:12] And I quote from the battle hem of the republic, as he died to make men holy, let us die to make men free. We got a habit of that in America. It was great in 1866, when Robert E. Lee, who fought for something that was wrong, because he did defend slavery, was implored by someone not far from here, Mr. Lee, to cause this law, so what shall we do?

[01:03:30] And he said, "Set aside your hatred and raise your children as Americans." That's pretty awesome, considering what a failure he'd been in defending something that's indefensible. It was great in 1951, when a schoolgirl in Prince Edward County, Virginia, who was told known not just by her parents, but by her teachers and by her clergy, said, if my uncle Vernon Johns is right when he reads, all men are created equal, then how come some people are more equal than us? And let the only student walk out led by a student to be amalgamated in the Brown v. Board of Education. I love Barbara Johns. It was great in 1956 when the

[01:04:06] Supreme Court ruled in Brown. It was great in 1964 when the Voting Rights Act was supported almost unanimously by Republicans and propelled by a racist Democrat. Look up Lyndon Johnson.

[01:04:22] See these people, they're complicated. It was great in 2000, excuse me, it was great in 2016 when a Republican senator from Buckingham handed off one bill to a Republican from Lynchburg that made April 23 Barbara Johnstay in Virginia before that Republican senator went off to Washington, D.C. to fail.

[01:04:47] See in that way, I'm a little bit like America and so are all of you guys because you wouldn't be sitting here if you weren't. I have failed, but I have never, ever been a failure. Now, let me digress another moment, because I'm fired up, Mr. Speaker. God took David, who sat on a rooftop and looked at a woman and said, she's so beautiful, maybe I can have her husband murdered so she can be mine, and made him a man after his own heart.

[01:05:13] God took the Apostle Paul, whose job was to persecute people who weren't like him for 20-some-odd years, and used him to write two-thirds of the New Testament. Man, I mean, imperfect vehicles can do near-perfect things, and that's why I love America.

[01:05:31] I'm thinking like you quoted a song. I got Joni Mitchell. Don't it always seem to go that you don't know what you got till it's gone. Be careful what you destroy because you don't know what you might replace it with. I'm going to tell you when else we fail.

[01:05:52] I want to have this conversation. I love you guys because some of y'all I don't like, but I'm commanded to love you. We fail when we hate each other. We fail when we say to my friend AC Cordoza, oh, you're skin folk, not kin folk. That's wrong. And you know it. We fail when we lie.

[01:06:09] We fail when they say they want to put you back in chains. Who? I'll go with you to get them. I will fight with you to stop that. We could compare ourselves to other countries. I've been to a lot of them. In Bosnia, Christians of the Orthodox persuasion murdered Christians of the Catholic persuasion when they weren't able to murder Muslims who murdered both of the Christians when they were able to.

[01:06:31] Not in America. The fact that the death toll from a country that has indeed done the evil things that we have done is about 800,000, including the Civil War and the Civil Rights Movement. Wow. That's pretty awesome. In other countries it would have been much higher, Rwanda, a million people murdered with machetes while the world turned a blind eye over tribal differences?

[01:06:52] Man, America's awesome. Germany, well, we won't even talk about them, right? Japan, I don't know, Rape of Nan King, Korean Comfort Girls, Egypt, Turkey, what they've done to their Kurdish population. Great Britain, well, they're pretty good, they've abolished slavery way before the Americans.

[01:07:09] Mr. Speaker, there are tens of millions of people still alive right now who remember being under the yoke of British colonial rule. Mr. Speaker, I know. I got the look. I got it. The United States is uniquely different because we routinely send our sons and daughters to die for people who are not like us, and that makes us special.

[01:07:25] We are great, we were great, and we can be greater, but what we can't do is destroy this special experiment, imperfect though it may be, that is America, by telling our children that it is evil, when, indeed, it is both evil and good, and we together can make it even better.

[01:07:45] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Delegate from Chesterfield, Delegate Doherty.

[01:08:03] Mr. Speaker, I ask that we return in the first morning hour for the purposes of an introduction. The Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I move that the House take up out of order House Joint Resolution 151 on page number 9 of today's calendar. Clerk before the resolution.

[01:08:19] House Joint Resolution 151, commending Curtis Allen. The Delegate from Chesterfield, Delegate Doherty. Mr. Speaker, I move the adoption of the resolution and I request to speak to the motion. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Can Curtis Allen and his friends and family with him please rise?

[01:08:38] Today, we proudly recognize Curtis Allen of the illustrious Virginia Union University as the 2025 recipient of the Harlan Hill Trophy, presented annually to the NCAA Division II National Player of the Year. With this achievement, he made history as the first student athlete from HBCU, the Central Intercollegiate Athletic Association, and the Commonwealth of Virginia to earn this prestigious honor.

[01:09:05] It is widely regarded as a Division II equivalent of the Heisman Trophy. Known nationally as Mr. 2K and in the locker room as Quiet Storm, Curtis rushed for a record-breaking 2,409 yards and 30 touchdowns, setting NCAA Division II and CIAA single-season records.

[01:09:27] He led Virginia Union to its third consecutive CIAA championship appearance and fourth straight NCAA playoff berth, redefining excellence and bringing immense pride to Virginia. Curtis Allen's historic season is a testament to perseverance, discipline, Panther pride, and the entire Commonwealth celebrates his achievement.

[01:09:47] Mr. Speaker, members of the House, as we pass this resolution, please join me in giving a warm House welcome and congratulations to Curtis Allen.

[01:10:03] Delegate from Chesterfield, Delegate Doherty moves at the House, adopt house joint resolution 151 commending curtis allen all those in favor say aye all those opposed no the resolution is agreed to congratulations delegate from hampton delegate ward thank you mr

[01:10:43] speaker mr speaker i ask permission to return to the first first morning hour for introduction the delegate has the floor thank you mr speaker mr speaker joining us in the capital today are members some of our labor friends who support and are the backbone of the data center industry Several of them are in the gallery with us today, and I ask that they stand.

[01:11:07] Mr. Speaker, we have members of the International Brotherhood of Electrical Workers, IBEW Local 26, IBEW Local 666, IBEW 1340, IBEW Local 456, IBEW 80, and the Mid-Atlantic Pipe Fitters Association.

[01:11:24] These union members are instrumental in the construction and maintenance of Virginia's data center industry, which has invested $80 billion into this Commonwealth over the last two years and supports over 74,000 jobs.

[01:11:41] This labor organization has worked almost 30 million hours over the last decade building and establishing the data center industry in the Commonwealth. This has allowed thousands of Virginia households to rise into middle class with good jobs, higher wages, health care, and retirement benefits.

[01:12:02] Mr. Speaker, members of the House, please join me in welcoming to the Capitol the International Brotherhood of Electrical Workers. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[01:12:23] The delegate from Roanoke, Delegate Rasul. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for a point of personal privilege. The delegate has the floor in two minutes. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. We walk in the shoes that come before us, Mr. Speaker. My predecessor, God rest his soul, was Delegate Ansley Ware, and I know that he was a mentor to several folks, including the chairman.

[01:12:48] He told me three things before I came down here. He said, first thing, your first year, sit down and shut up. And now the freshman is like, why didn't you tell us that, Sam? Second, Mr. Speaker, I went to him and I said, you know, honestly, there's a, you know, they're running an African-American Republican against me in the general election.

[01:13:14] They're trying to divide the black vote. He said, let me tell you something about black voters. I said, of course, people want to root for people who look like them. But he said, black voters do not want to be embarrassed, number one.

[01:13:31] And number two, they want people who carry their values. And I tell you that election night, we saw that through and through to his credit and his intelligence. And then lastly, Mr. Speaker, he said, you know, there's a balance between being relevant and being right.

[01:13:49] You know, and being right all the time, Mr. Speaker, actually is a point of privilege. It comes from a point of privilege when you get to just be from a certain part of society feel like it doesn't matter what anyone else thinks. I have something to say. Mr. Speaker, many years ago, someone came into, we, believe it or not, Roanoke, Mr. Speaker, has projects.

[01:14:16] I know people don't think about that, but there's some projects in Roanoke. We had a little convenience store in next to one of the projects. And this young man came in and robbed my father. He came in, there was a little scuffle. He stole the money from the register. He had something, he was wearing something. But as he left, my father knew who the guy was. And my mom came in shortly thereafter. And she's like, oh, let's call the police. So she called the police. That's that and the other. My dad was trying to play it down. And we didn't understand exactly why. Because he

[01:14:51] knew that mother of that young black man. He knew exactly how that family was going to be devastated over, I don't know, a couple hundred dollars and what was going to happen. He did everything he could. Well, court date came, Mr. Speaker. And wouldn't you know, that young black man walked into my dad's store. He's like, Ralph, I don't have a ride. My dad's like, I'll give you a ride. So the young man who had just robbed my father a few weeks before gets in the car,

[01:15:28] they go to court. My dad does his best to talk everybody down. And that just shows, Mr. Speaker, how things are more complicated than we would have them believe. Many people would hear this

story and talk about, we need to be tough on crime.

[01:15:48] This young man needs to learn his lesson. But my father knew that mother, and that that mother needed a break. And when Ansley talked to me about relevance and right, there's a time to be right, and there's a time to figure out how we're going to be relevant in improving society.

[01:16:08] And I'm appreciative of that, Mr. Speaker. And as we think about some of the difficult decisions that people of color, people from a variety of socioeconomic statuses, the decisions that they make, it's so easy for us to say what's wrong with them why are they doing that why would they make that decision i hope that we can challenge ourselves most importantly mr speaker and understanding our privilege and hopefully that'll give us an understanding of where people are really coming

[01:16:40] from thank you so much mr speaker it is time for the special and continuing order on house bill 30 the clerk will report house bill 30 special and continuing order the house of delegates for this Thursday, February 26, 2026, page 6 of the printed calendar, House Bill 30, which would provide for all appropriations of the budget and provide a portion of the revenues for the two years ending respectively on the 30th day of June 2027 and the 30th day of

[01:17:17] June 2028, as well as the bill would repeal portions of the Acts of Assembly of 2022 effective for taxable years beginning on and after January 1, 2027. Legislation report committing on appropriation with amendments. Those amendments are printed separately, eligible to the members here in the chamber and to the public via the legislative information system.

[01:17:37] House Bill 30 is now before you. Delegate from Prince William, Delegatorian. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I'd like to briefly speak to House Bill 30. The delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, on yesterday, the director of the House Appropriations Committee gave a high-level presentation to both caucuses.

[01:17:57] She shared with them, with both caucuses, the hard work that have gone into this budget, sharing with them that there are priorities that we sought to address as we kept in mind the over 8.4 million Virginians that we have been called to serve to make sure that they have a quality of life where they can raise their families, educate their children, pay their bills.

[01:18:27] Mr. Speaker, during the course of this session, many of us received a large number of emails from citizens concerned about the budget, concerned about taxes and things of that nature.

[01:18:46] They had seen a lot of legislation being introduced relative to taxes. And Mr. Speaker, I want to share with this House and share with this Commonwealth that the House of Delegates, we have put together a budget where there are no new taxes in this budget.

[01:19:05] And we have met the requirements of a balanced budget here today that is before you. And it's my great hope that we all can appreciate and value the work that we've done as we've tried to represent you and as we've tried to represent the citizens of the Commonwealth.

[01:19:21] And with that, Mr. Speaker, I would request that the clerk report the committee amendments for which there is an objection. The clerk will report those objections. Mr. Speaker, members of the House, committee approved amendments. There are 421 of them in the book.

[01:19:40] There have been objections to 30 of that 421. I'll list them by page number in this document that you all have and is available to the public and item number. All of them are at the request of Delegate

Kilgore, save one. Page five, an objection was raised to item number one, number eight H.

[01:20:01] On page 13, all three items there, items 50, number one H, 50, number two H, and 50, number three H, has objection to those three. Overall, on page 14, an objection has been raised to item 54, number one H.

[01:20:18] On page 15, an objection has been raised to item 60, number one H. On page 22, an objection has been raised to item 77, number 4H. On page 33 of the committee amendments, an objection has been raised to item 102, number 6H.

[01:20:37] Moving to page 60, an objection to item 125, number 1H. Page 102, an objection has been raised to item 243, number 1H. On page 111 of the committee amendments, an objection has been raised to item 278, number 3H.

[01:20:54] Page 119, an objection has been raised to item 290, number 1H. Page 144, objection to item 328, number 1H. Page 151, objection to item 352, number 1H.

[01:21:11] Page 152, an objection has been raised to item 352, number 3H. On page 155, an objection has been raised to item 359, number 1H. On page 163, an objection is raised to item 369, number 1H.

[01:21:29] Continuing on the committee amendments over on page 183, an objection is raised to item 399, number 2H. On page 187, both items there, objections have been raised for 419, number 1H, and item 419, number 2H.

[01:21:48] On page 189, an objection is raised to item 420, number 3H. Page 198 of the committee amendments, objections raised to item 471, number 1H. On page 199, objections raised to both items there, items 471, number 2H and 471, number 3H.

[01:22:08] On page 200, objections raised to item 471, number 4H. On page 201, item 471, number 5H has an objection. On page 206, item 491, number 1H.

[01:22:23] On page 214, objections are raised to item C-18, number 1H. That objection has been made by Delegate Wilt. On page 230, penultimately, objections are raised to item 4-5.04, number 1H.

[01:22:39] And lastly, an objection is raised to item 230, on page 235, an objection is raised to item 4-14, number 2H. Those objections, the rest of them, are in a larger block. Are there further objections?

[01:22:58] The delegate from Prince William, delegatorian. Mr. Speaker, I move that the remaining committee amendments for which there is no objection be agreed to in block. Shall the remaining committee amendments for which there is no objection be agreed to in block? This is a regarded vote.

[01:23:27] Clerk will close the roll. Ayes 89, nos 9. Ayes 89, nos 9. The amendments are agreed to. Clerk will now proceed. The delegate from Alexander, Delegate Herring. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[01:23:43] Mr. Speaker, I rise for a motion. Delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker I move that the House stand in recess until 1:39. Deluxe Alexander, Delica Herring moves that the House stand in recess until 1:39. All those in favor say aye. Aye. All those opposed, no. The House is in recess until 1:39.



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